WEEK 2 · LESSON 8 OF 24 · HANDOUT

Core AI Tools for Everyday Work

Study time: **about 45 minutes** (reading, video and activity)

▶ **Watch:** https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=htZRCE2GgIs — open the lesson online to watch inside the course.

🎓 **Go deeper:** Harvard CS50x 2024: Artificial Intelligence — full lecture — https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6X58aP7yXC4

Your goal in this lesson: Recognise the main categories of AI tools, choose the right tool for a task, and set up a simple free toolkit.

You already have more than you think

You do not need expensive software to start. Most useful AI today falls into a few categories, and free versions cover most everyday needs. Tools change fast, so learn the **categories**; the names may change, the categories will not.

The main categories

Category	Examples	Best for
General assistants	ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude, Microsoft Copilot	Writing, explaining, planning, brainstorming
Search assistants	Perplexity, AI answers in Google and Bing	Questions where you need sources and recent information
Document & study tools	NotebookLM, AI in Google Docs and Microsoft Word	Working with *your own* files: summarise, question, study
Office assistants	Copilot in Excel/PowerPoint, Gemini in Sheets/Slides	Formulas, charts, slides from your notes
Design tools	Canva AI, image generators	Posters, social-media graphics, presentations
Meeting & voice tools	Transcription and note-taking assistants	Turning meetings and lectures into notes
Coding assistants	GitHub Copilot, AI in code editors	Writing and explaining code

How to choose the right tool

Ask three questions:

1. **Do I need current facts with sources?** → use a search assistant, or a general assistant with web search turned on.
2. **Is the task about my own documents?** → use a document tool where you upload the files (and never upload confidential files to a tool you do not trust).
3. **Is it general writing or thinking?** → a general assistant is enough.

Free versus paid

Free plans are usually enough to learn and for light daily use. Paid plans add newer models, larger uploads and more messages per day. **Start free.** Pay only when a tool clearly saves you more time or money than it costs. Many tools also offer discounts for students and teachers.

Working on a phone and with slow internet

- Most general assistants have free mobile apps — useful for quick drafts and voice questions.
- Voice input can be faster than typing long prompts.
- Text answers use little data; images and video use much more.
- Save useful answers in your notes so you do not need to ask again.

Your starter toolkit

A simple, free setup that covers almost everything in this course:

1. **One general assistant** you learn deeply (pick one and stick with it for this course).
2. **One search assistant** for questions that need sources.
3. **One document tool** for studying your own notes and readings.
4. **Canva** (or a similar tool) for visuals.

Remember this: Master one general assistant first, add specialised tools only when a task needs them, and always match the tool to the job.

Name: _____ Date: _____

Activity

Task 1

Choose your **main general assistant** and create a free account if needed.

Task 2

Ask the same question in your general assistant **and** in a search assistant: *"What are the current requirements to register a small business in Rwanda?"*

Task 3

Compare: Which answer gave sources? Which seemed more up to date? Check one detail on the official website (for example RDB's business registration page).

Task 4

Write down your starter toolkit (4 tools) and what you will use each one for.

Self-check

Think about your answers here, then take the quiz online — it is marked instantly and explains every answer.

1. Which type of tool is best when you need recent facts WITH sources?
   - A. A meeting transcription tool
   - B. A coding assistant
   - C. A search assistant
   - D. A design tool
2. You want to ask questions about your own lecture notes. Which category fits best?
   - A. Coding assistants
   - B. Document and study tools
   - C. Image generators
   - D. None — AI cannot read documents
3. What is the recommended first step for building your AI toolkit?
   - A. Master one general assistant first
   - B. Buy every paid plan
   - C. Use ten tools at once
   - D. Wait until AI is perfect
4. When does paying for an AI tool make sense?
   - A. Only if your friends pay
   - B. When it clearly saves more time or money than it costs
   - C. Never
   - D. Always, immediately
5. Why learn tool CATEGORIES rather than only tool names?
   - A. Names are hard to spell
   - B. Tools change fast, but the categories stay useful
   - C. Only categories work in Rwanda
   - D. Categories are cheaper
6. What should you NEVER upload to an AI tool you do not trust?
   - A. A public news article
   - B. A famous poem
   - C. A recipe
   - D. Confidential client or personal files

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